Your Abstract Submission Has Been Received!

You have submitted the following abstract to XXI ISA World Congress of Sociology (July 4 - 10, 2027). Receipt of this notice does not guarantee that your submission was complete or free of errors.

Print this page

Deservingness Criteria In the Allocation of Educational Benefits In Higher Education: A Distributional Survey Experiment Approach

Juan Carlos CASTILLO, Universidad de Chile, Chile and Tomás URZÚA MORENO, University of Chile, Chile

Abstract Text:
The social welfare literature has long debated the principles that should guide the allocation of public goods and benefits. In this context, the deservingness criteria (Knotz, 2022; Meulemann et al, 2020;Van Oorschot, 2000) have emerged as a key framework for understanding how individuals perceive the fairness of distributing benefits in different welfare domains. These criteria often include factors such as need, effort, attitude, and identity, which individuals take into account when evaluating the deservingness of others. In the present study, we aim to explore how deservingness criteria affect the decisions in benefits' allocation for access to higher education (scholarships). For this, we use a distributional survey experiment (DSE) (Gilgen, 2022), a methodology that combines the characteristics of conjoints, factorial surveys, and allocation experiments, allowing researchers to systematically manipulate the characteristics of hypothetical beneficiaries and observe how these manipulations influence respondents' allocation decisions. Our main argument is that the deservingness criterion of effort --linked to preferences for meritocracy-- would outweigh egalitarian criteria in the allocation of scholarships amounts. Using data from a novel survey experiment conducted in Chile in 2026 (N=4,500), we tested the effects of different deservingness criteria on the allocation of educational benefits, as well as how such criteria interact with individual characteristics as socio-economic status, gender, political orientation, and preferences for meritocratic distribution. The findings from this experimental approach contribute to the broader literature on social welfare and public opinion, providing insights into how individuals prioritize different factors when determining who deserves access to higher education.

Group: RC42 Social Psychology

Session Selection: Meritocracy, Deservingness, and Inequality

Title: Deservingness Criteria In the Allocation of Educational Benefits In Higher Education: A Distributional Survey Experiment Approach

Submitter's E-mail Address: juancastillov@uchile.cl

Keywords: Deservingness, Distributive justice, Social wlefare and Survey experiments

First Author

Primary Author

Juan Carlos CASTILLO
Universidad de Chile, Chile
E-mail Address: juancastillov@uchile.cl

Second Author

Tomás URZÚA MORENO
University of Chile, Chile
E-mail Address: tomas.urzua@ug.uchile.cl

If necessary, you can make changes to your abstract submission until Wednesday, 14 October 2026.

To access your submission in the future, visit your User Portal page.

Any changes that you make will be reflected instantly in what is seen by the reviewers. You DO NOT need to go through all of the submission steps in order to change one thing. If you want to change the title, for example, just click "Title" in the abstract control panel and submit the new title.

When you have completed your submission, you may close this browser window.

Tell us what you think of the abstract submission process

ISA Home Page